

MODULE 01

Cohosting 101: What This Actually Is

Cohosting is the practice of managing a short-term rental property on behalf of an owner who cannot — or does not want to — manage it themselves. This module sets the operating definition we will use across every other module in this kit. If you take only one thing from this module, it is the difference between a cohost and a property manager.

The operating definition

A cohost is an individual or small team who handles the day-to-day operations of someone else's short-term rental listing. They do not own the property. They do not hold the master booking calendar. They usually do not have a property management license. They have a contract with the owner and a share of the booking revenue.

What you actually do, end-to-end:

- Take and respond to guest inquiries and booking requests
- Manage the listing on Airbnb, VRBO, Furnished Finder, and any direct-booking channel
- Set dynamic pricing daily based on demand, seasonality, and local events
- Schedule cleanings between bookings and verify quality
- Coordinate maintenance calls and vendor visits
- Handle guest issues (lockouts, complaints, damage claims)
- Send monthly statements to the owner with revenue, expenses, and net payout

What a cohost is not

A property manager is the license-holder and the legally accountable party for guest safety, building code compliance, and trust accounting. Some jurisdictions — New York City, for example — require a property management license for any short-term-rental operator who touches guest money across more than one property. Most cohosts do not need this license; they operate as independent contractors under the owner's existing licensing.

If your market requires a license for what you are doing, this kit is not the right starting point. Get licensed first, then return.

How the money flows

The cohosting revenue models are percentage-based, flat-fee, or hybrid. Each one shifts your incentives and your tax exposure. Module 04 covers pricing in depth; here is the summary:

Percentage model: 20-30% of booking subtotal. Common. Aligns your incentive with the owner's revenue. Taxable as self-employment income in the US.

Flat-fee model: \$X per booking or \$X per month. Predictable for the owner. You take on utilization risk.

Hybrid: Lower percentage + a base fee. Common at higher-end markets with high-ADR listings.

What this kit does not cover

We do not cover how to set up your LLC, how to open a bank account, or how to do your taxes. Those depend on your jurisdiction and your personal situation. Get a CPA in your first 90 days of cohosting if you do not already have one.

We do not cover how to run paid acquisition for guest bookings. Module 09 covers owner outreach, which is a different motion. Paid acquisition of guests is the owner's responsibility.

Module 01 — Done. Module 02 covers how to position yourself in the cohosting market so owners can find and trust you.